

c. 250–476 CE

THE DECLINE AND FALL OF ROME

By the 4th century, the Roman Empire was under increasing pressure from barbarians intent on plundering or settling within the empire. The costs and bureaucracy needed to defend its borders could not be supported, and the empire was unable to cope with attacks on multiple fronts, suffering frequent incursions that devastated its frontier provinces. To manage the threat, the empire was forced to recruit barbarian mercenaries to man its armies, and even its best generals, such as Flavius Stilicho (c. 359–408 CE), were of Germanic origin.

From the 390s CE, Alaric and his Goths devastated the Balkans, even invading Italy; and in 407 CE a large group of Vandals, Alans, and Sueves crossed the Rhine into Gaul, and occupied much of Spain and North Africa. With central control receding, the empire's tax base shrank and it became unable to defend its provinces in the west. Rome was sacked by Vandals and the last Western Emperor, Romulus Augustulus, was deposed by his Germanic army chief Odovacer in 476 CE. In contrast, the Eastern Roman emperors stabilized the Balkans, and their line survived almost 1,000 years.



KEY MOMENTS

c. 250–476 CE Protecting the borders

A weakened Roman Empire responded to the barbarian threat by reinforcing its frontiers. The army became divided into frontier garrisons (see *left*) and elite mobile field armies in a system that was costly to fund.

c. 409–800 CE The Germanic kingdoms

The Germanic barbarians established kingdoms in the Roman provinces they occupied: the Franks in Gaul, the Visigoths (*left*) in Spain, and the Ostrogoths in Italy. Except in Britain, their rulers based themselves in old Roman cities and made use of former Roman officials in their governments.

452 CE Pope Leo I meets Attila the Hun

Attila, king of the Huns, led an army across the Danube into Northern Italy, taking ten cities. An embassy led by Pope Leo I (*left*) met with Attila in an attempt to persuade him not to march on Rome. The Huns withdrew, but probably to avoid harsh winter conditions.

